iDNAtity Crisis

by John Pete



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GURU. What's up, dudes? Welcome to couples yoga, 'k? Let us begin our journey by facing our partners, 'k?

PETER. June? Are you sure that this is a good idea?

JUNE. Yes, Peter. You're always talking about getting to know your true self, plus you said you wanted to see yoga.

PETER. I wanted to watch yoga. That's different. Sometimes I feel like you don't get me… (*bit*) Ow! June, something bit me!

JUNE. It was probably a spider. Just get a Band-Aid.

GURU. Shhh, now move to our next pose: the intergalactic tree-frog. Focus on your true self with this one, 'k.

PETER. True self…spider bite… (*puts two and two together, realizes*) Gasp! June! Spider-Man!

JUNE. What?

PETER. I'm Spider-Man!

JUNE. You're not Spider-Man. You're afraid of heights. And spiders. And also men.

PETER. That was before I was genetically mutated! I can feel it in my DNA! I'm special now.

GURU. SHHH! If you cannot silently find enlightenment then, like, make like the Buddha and peace out, 'k?

PETER. I am Spider-Man. I'm gonna get a DNA test and prove it to you.

JUNE. A DNA test? That's not gonna tell you who you are.

PETER. You'll see! You'll ALL see! Namaste!!!

According to Newsweek from April 2, 2018, nearly half of at-home DNA test turn out to be wrong. Which explains why Ancestry.com's slogan of "Discover what makes you" recently changed to "(shrug) your guess is as good as ours." For Peter, the heroic quest to discover his identity is plagued with the annoying reality that our genes tell us very little about who we really are…unless, of course, your jeans have rhinestones on them, then we know EXACTLY who you are. iDNAtity Crisis by Jonathan Pete

PETER. June! Guess whose DNA test came in the mail? THIS GUY (*does Spider-man—similar to "I love you" in sign language— hands towards himself with left hand)*

JUNE. Oh, great. Another $250 spent to tell you you're an idiot.

PETER. Ha! It was $230. Jokes on you.

JUNE. Peter, you're not Spider-Man. We've been through stuff like this before, like when you thought you could speak to birds.

PETER. Ok, that parrot seemed VERY conversational.

JUNE. Or the time you thought you could predict the future.

PETER. I knew you were gonna bring that up.

JUNE. Or the time you thought you were being recruited by the CIA.

PETER. That black suburban followed us for BLOCKS. Besides, this is science so it has to be true.

JUNE. Peter, A DNA test isn't going to tell you you're a superhero, it's going to tell you your ancestry: your dad is…

PETER. **…**German and French.

JUNE. And your mom is...

PETER. **…**Dutch-Italian.

JUNE. So your DNA test is going to reveal that you're a German, French, Italian who wears wooden shoes.

PETER. Let's just see, shall we?

JUNE. Huh… Not only are you not Spider-Man. It says you don't share any of the ancestry that your parents have. Which would mean…

PETER. That… they are not Spider-Man.

JUNE. (*holding the paper*) That they are not your parents. Where did you get this from? Ancestry.com? MyHeritage?

PETER. Ah some website called Pedigree in Me.

JUNE. You got an off-brand DNA test?

PETER. Dr. Zark Muckerberg is very prestigious. He's got a ton of positive Facebook reviews.

JUNE. Well, I think you need to challenge the results of this test.

PETER. You're right. We need to get to the bottom of this…right after a slight costume change.

TRANSITION

PETER. (*enters uncomfortably*) I'm ready.

JUNE. (*she now has a purse*) Why did you insist on wearing a lycra unitard under your clothes?

PETER. Ha! Unitard? (*rotates uncomfortably*) Uh, it's called a supersuit. You never know when trouble will strike, June. I'm just still getting used to the way it (*a little aggressive*) rides up.

TRANSITION

ZARK. Welcome to Pedigree in Me. How can I help you?

JUNE. We are here to contest the results of a DNA test.

PETER. Yeah, I am Spider-Man!

JUNE. Peter.

PETER. I mean, no, I am NOT adopted. (*finger to the sky*) A mistake has been made.

ZARK. Impossible. Dr. Zark Muckerberg doesn't make mistakes. I would know, for I am Dr. Zark Muckerberg! Ooooh!

PETER. Wow. It's an honor to meet you, sir. I have seen many, many Facebook posts about how great you are.

ZARK. (*smug*) Yes, I wrote most of them! Now then, what seems to be the trouble?

PETER. Trouble?

JUNE. No, Peter. No, Dr. Muckerberg. My boyfriend Peter took your DNA test for…

PETER. Webs, webs, webs, shoooot!

JUNE. ...obtuse reasons, and the results that came back don't match any of his parental ancestry.

ZARK. Aha, so you're adopted. (*nonsensically deep*) Aren't we all?

JUNE. The thing is, he's not adopted.

ZARK. Aha, so you were switched at birth. (*again, nonsensically deep*) Aren't we all?

PETER. But what if my DNA was so powerful it messed with your science machines? Like hypothetically if I happened to be a genetically mutated spider…

ZARK. Aha, so you're a paranoid schizophrenic with delusions of grandeur. (*again*) Aren't we all?

JUNE. We'd like you to run the test again, just to...you know, double-check?

ZARK. No need. I perform all the tests myself.

JUNE. Mmmhmm… (*get the results out*) It says he's 70% Persian, 20% Sub-saharan African, and varying percentages of Asian and Babylonian.

PETER. That's not me at all! -

ZARK. Well, wah wah wah. I guess you should've been 100% baby-lonian. Let me call the Wah-mbulance.

PETER. I'm not being a baby!

JUNE. He's just trying to figure out who he is.

PETER. I know who I am. I am Spider-Man! Supersuit (*rips open clothes*) activate!

JUNE. Oh. Peter, you...you ripped off everything...

PETER. ... activate?

TRANSITION

JUNE. Well, we tried, sweetie.

PETER. I know you think I'm crazy,

JUNE. Well, you are standing on the street wearing a garbage bag telling me you're Spider-Man.

PETER. Yeah, you right. But the thing is, I'm not ready to give up yet. My spidey-sense is tingling.

JUNE. Honey (*goes into the purse*) that's probably chaffing from the garbage bag. (*hands him the powder*) Here's some talcum powder.

PETER. Muckerberg is hiding something. And we need to break into that facility and find out what.

JUNE. Why?

PETER. Because... With great powder comes great responsibility. It's Spider-Man time!

JUNE. (*watches him run across*) Peter! (*watches him jump up*) That drainpipe isn't gonna...you're gonna… (*he falls*) Why don't we just use side door?

PETER. (*Peter infiltrates*) This is Dr. Muckerberg's lab? (*relaxes to normal*) I thought there would be… like machines and like… smart stuff.

JUNE. Yeah, It's just…a giant map on the wall…(*picks something up*) why is there a dart on the floor?

(door opens)

PETER. Quick, hide!

ZARK. Very well… (*looks at paper*) Ms. Stephanie Smith… (*unscrews and loads*) your DNA profile is (*individual darts*) aha! 30% South Korean (*throws another dart*) and, ooooh, 40% North Korean… (*notices June and Peter*) Kim Jong Uh-Oh!

PETER. That's your secret?! You throw darts at a map!?

ZARK. Gasp! The Babylonian!

PETER. I've caught you red handed! Or should I say… in a WEB OF LIES!

ZARK. How dare you break into my lab and make a mockery my science missiles! Take this and that! (*throws darts*)

PETER. June, look out! (*gets hit with a dart*)

JUNE. PETER!

PETER. He got me!

ZARK. You damned millennials and your endless nauseating desire to "know who you are." You cannot stop me! Me and science will take over the world. Muaha— what are you doing?

JUNE. Live Facebook feed.

PETER. Namaste, Dork Suckerberg.

ZARK. Data breach! (*runs away*)

TRANSITION

PETER. Well, I guess I'm not Babylonian…or Spider-Man.

JUNE. Who needs Spider-Man? I've got a guy who exposed a fraudulent science empire, exposed himself, and took a dart in his rear for me. No DNA result is ever going explain why you are the wonderful way you are. Your true self is who you have become, not where you came from.

PETER. Aww, thanks. It'd still be cool if I was Spider-Man. *(He gestures and web shoots out of his hand and surprises him. He freezes, slow build into shock and joy.)*